

Legacy Modernisation Curve

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Optimise old systems vs. rebuild

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Legacy Modernisation Curve depicts the trade-off between continuing to optimise an existing system and rebuilding it, showing how returns to optimisation flatten while a rebuild offers a higher but riskier trajectory.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A practitioner model from enterprise-architecture and digital-transformation practice, related to technical-debt and application-portfolio theory.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

It was developed to help organisations recognise when incremental improvement of a legacy estate has exhausted its returns and a step change is warranted.

FIGURE 1 · LEGACY MODERNISATION CURVE

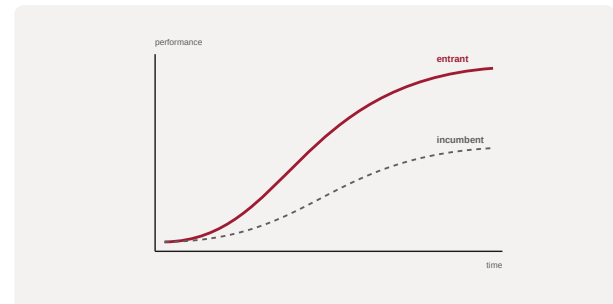


Figure 1. A schematic of the Legacy Modernisation Curve as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

Current systems are plotted on the curve; diminishing optimisation returns are weighed against the cost, risk and upside of modernisation or AI-native rebuild.

WHEN IT IS USED

When deciding whether to layer AI onto legacy systems or re-platform, and during transformation planning.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Enterprise architects, CIOs and transformation leads.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It makes the optimise-versus-rebuild decision explicit and time-dependent, countering the inertia of perpetual incremental patching.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Embedded vs. AI-Native 2x2 · Slibrary 3

Build · Buy · Partner · Slibrary 3

Value Proposition Canvas · Slibrary 3

Data Network Effects · Slibrary 3

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Gartner (2019) '7 Options to Modernize Legacy Systems'.

Ross, J.W., Weill, P. and Robertson, D. (2006) Enterprise Architecture as Strategy. Boston: HBR Press.